

Personal Philosophy of Education

Jim D. Pham

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What is my personal philosophy of education? This question has been posed time and again by many individuals, and now it is my turn to respond. As I reflect on this inquiry, it prompts me to consider even more questions about myself: “Who am I?”, “Where am I, and how do I navigate my journey from here?”, “What are my beliefs?”, and “What are my values?”. I have concluded that crafting a personal philosophy of education is akin to formulating a philosophy of my life. Though this question pertains to my individual perspective on education, it also significantly shapes my identity.

I have consistently contemplated my philosophical beliefs and educational practices, yet I often find myself uncertain when I compare them against various educational theories and philosophical ideals. Perhaps this uncertainty arises from my reliance on education and growth across all facets of my development. There are five common educational philosophies recognized within the field of education: Behaviorism, Essentialism, Existentialism, Perennialism, and Progressivism. Each of these theories possesses both positive and negative aspects, at least from my viewpoint. I believe that one must genuinely know oneself to make an eclectic and informed choice regarding educational philosophy. Ultimately, I think that who we are fundamentally influences our educational practices.

To achieve self-actualization, I must evaluate my beliefs, the essence of truth, and the values encompassed by philosophy—metaphysics, epistemology, and axiology. Simultaneously, I am engaged in comparing philosophical beliefs with educational practices. Through this ongoing process of self-discovery, I am better equipped to answer my own questions about education, gain a deeper understanding of my true self, and ultimately grow into a more effective educator.

About Me

I think that it is also important to share some of my personal thoughts, “about me”, personality, and beliefs. I have had many roles in my life: an engineer, a teacher, a husband, and a father of my two children. Each of my roles is equally important in defining who I am, and I am a leader and a servant. I believe that a leader needs a vision of the future, a sense of direction, and a grasp of reality. In addition, a leader must believe in oneself, lead by example, and lead by doing. I am an educator and a public servant because I want to support the public school system and help others succeed. I also believe that my values are at the core of my beliefs, my life values, and my educational direction. I believe that success is measured by old-fashioned hard work, dedication, and an unrelenting devotion to the things you do. That is what I strive to do in each role in my life.

As an engineer, I have to work with other engineers to develop a design solution to address a business problem. I like to work on project teams where team building is essential to the project's success. I believe in teamwork, and when people truly work as a team, they can produce breakthrough results. In this role in my life, I try to be a good team player, be accountable, and listen well. I believe that to be an effective team, you have to help team members, team leaders, and coaches identify their strengths and weaknesses.

As a teacher, I believe that to be a successful and effective instructor, one must be able to multitask, be consistent and firm, accept individual differences, and provide personal assistance to students. I believe that education does not exist only in a classroom. I am an educator in many different roles in my life. As the first in my family to go to college, I have found that I have been a role model and a teacher for as long as I can remember. I have tutored my siblings, friends, and now my own children. I guess I was first inspired by my own parents and my teachers. I believe that teaching is a gift as much as music is, and not everyone is talented enough to be really good at it. I believe I am an expert in what I teach, and I am talented enough to help people appreciate and respect the subjects I teach. In my field of expertise, Computer Engineering, I wanted others to benefit from my knowledge and experience, but more importantly, I desired that my students develop an intrinsic sense of self-worth and direction through learning from their experiences.

I am, most importantly, a loving parent and husband, an exemplary employee, and a team player. I have worked hard to maintain high standards at work and school simultaneously, so all aspects of my life have been rewarding.

My personality aligns with the humanistic approach of teaching, which emphasizes internal control. I encourage students to realize how their behavior impacts others' feelings and learning. I expect my students to operate within agreed-upon expectations and accept natural or logical consequences. I encourage cooperation, active participation, and self-discipline.

My unsung hero is my dad. Over the weekend, on Father's Day, I wanted to contribute to him as someone who had influenced my life. He has given me a new way of thinking about duty and responsibility: that duty comes with great responsibility. After the Fall of Saigon (Vietnam War, 1975), all the commanding officers of the South Vietnamese's Army fled the country for fear of prosecution from the communists. My dad made a conscious choice to stay with his army unit, and the communists captured him. He was sent to the re-educational camp for thirteen years. He was not a deserter like most commanding officers, but he was actually a prisoner of war. I had recently learned that he was one of the few people to surrender to the communist party because he said that there was no order from his change of command to dismantle his army. By the time the communists arrived at the city of Long An, where my father was a commanding officer, most of the South Vietnamese Army had already disintegrated

into the civilian population, and others fled to another country. For me, the sad part of the war is that no one knew or spoke about him. That is why I am so proud of my dad.

I was always wondering what my father was thinking at the time: love for family, duty to a falling country, or his soldiers. I must ask him someday, but in the face of danger, if you are presented with choices, then what will you do? As a leader, I believe that we must be aware of our decisions and actions, as they can affect other people's lives. I believe that only a strong personal conscience and strong ethical beliefs can determine your course of action.

Metaphysical Beliefs

From an anthropological perspective, I believe that all people are basically good, and I enjoy being a positive role model for others. Cosmological aspect: I believe the universe is an orderly system. Theological aspect: I am a Pantheist. I have deep faith in Catholicism, which plays an important part in my life. In a school setting, there should be clear boundaries on what is and is not taught. I want my students to know about things beyond the natural sciences, like metaphysics, the state beyond physical or material matter. Although I believe the role of religion is for each person to interpret, problems do not occur in a school setting. Ontologically, my life has presented me with many choices; it is up to me, along the way, to determine the choice's rockiness or smoothness. What is important for me is to turn negatives into positives, learn from my mistakes, and enjoy whichever choice I end up on.

Epistemological Beliefs

We are living in an epistemological world, and we were taught that there is no such thing as a bad question. The Platonic ideal, all genuine questions must have one true answer. I believe that this is true for science. I believe that the discovery of truth depends on sensory experience and sense of reality. Sensory experience comprises touch, sight, smell, taste, and sound. The sense of reality is a worldview encompassing society, the environment, and technological advances; reality is real because we believe it is. Different teachers can teach all subjects in different ways. The way a person learns is the only way to gain complete knowledge of the subject. Most of the values and ethics should be taught at home, not in a school setting. Teaching students the rights and wrongs in everyday situations is the responsibility of both teachers and parents. I believe that parents need to make sure that the kids know that they are not invincible; they will not always get away with drinking and driving.

Axiological Beliefs

I consider myself a well-rounded person. Axiologically, both ethics and aesthetics are very important to my life. During my undergraduate education, as a young man, I faced many ethical challenges, such as "what is a proper behavior of a man" and "how to be a better person". I wrote a quote for myself to live by: "Jim's, think before you do anything." After

eighteen years, I am still thinking about that quote. A strong ethical conscience is also evident in my life and in my classroom. At this stage of my life, I have a new quote: "Jim's, do the right thing." That is a guideline for me as a teacher and in my classroom. I think that most people know the right thing and just need to be reminded occasionally. I believe that the role of a teacher is to help students learn right from wrong and make positive choices. At the same time, I truly appreciate and enjoy beauty and point out what I consider beautiful things to my students all the time, be it a good student program, a good student design methodology, beautiful student artwork, a beautiful word, or a beautiful song.

My unsung hero is my dad. He has given me a new meaning to the ethical question that duty comes with great responsibility. As an educator, I have great responsibility to my students and in the subject context. My duty as a teacher is to teach the truth and, more importantly, to do the right thing.

Beliefs about Education

I believe that the purpose of education is to instill knowledge and know-how in every person capable of digesting and applying what they have learned. Education should be a tool for all people to learn, enjoy, understand, and reason with their lives. Education should encourage the acquisition of knowledge to appreciate ultimate realities. Such an education should affect the person in terms of who he/she is and enable them to understand their world better. Thus, educational experience should not be merely the gathering of facts but also the fostering of a worldview. I believe that education is knowledge, and knowledge helps you to adeptly function in an ever-changing world. I believe that education is a learned skill that everyone can be taught. I believe that education is available to whoever seriously wants it. I believe that education is essential to building civilization, especially as science and technology advance so rapidly.

I am a kind of teacher who likes to teach students to apply knowledge and problem-solving to real-world problems. The five educational theories that correspond, at least in part, to my ideals are Behaviorism, Essentialism, Existentialism, Perennialism, and Progressivism. In behaviorism, I agree with Skinner (1904-1989): rewards and motivation motivate students to learn material even if they do not fully understand why it will have value in their futures. Essentialists focus on basic knowledge, skills, and understandings that people should master. Perennialists focus on developing students' maximum capacity to reason and regard training in the humanities as particularly essential to the development of our rational powers. Existentialists believe in human free will and the need for individuals to shape their own futures, leaving the learning content up to the individual. My personal philosophy of education is closely aligned with a progressivist approach, a school of thought that holds that truth is determined by function. I believe that the curriculum is centered on activities and instruction that challenge

students' problem-solving and analytical abilities, strengthening these skills. I feel that, to become an effective teacher, I see myself combining aspects of all four philosophies to support development in all areas of growth. My approach is primarily centered on the needs of the students.

In some respects, I feel my whole life has been attached primarily to pragmatic ideals, with possibly an element of existentialism. As a child growing up during the Vietnam War, boat people, and refugees, I had to learn whatever skills were available to work and survive. In this highly stressful, fast-moving society where people always struggle to meet basic human needs, there are many needy students like me who find education challenging and may need motivation, guidance, and attention. I would like to be the "go-to" person for those who want to advance their lives. I was there and understood what it feels like to be alone and displaced. I do believe the world is an ever-changing place. A strong background in basic skills is not an end in itself but a foundation that will launch students into an ever-changing and challenging technological society. I believe that strong personal values, decision-making and problem-solving skills, and creative approaches are important prerequisites for success.

Progressivism is an educational philosophy focused on equipping students with the skills and knowledge necessary not only to survive but also to succeed in a contemporary, competitive society. The philosophy is based on the belief that people learn best from what they consider most relevant to their lives, experiences, interests, projects, and abilities. In concurrence, students soon become aware of which tools are needed to succeed and self-select them according to the situation. One of the aims is to help students develop the problem-solving skills that enable them to become productive adults who function adeptly in an ever-changing world. John Dewey (1859-1952) was considered one of the leading proponents of the revival and evolution of American education. He was the leading educational purveyor of progressive education. I agree with John Dewey's philosophy of progressivism and feel that students should learn through inquiry and by stimulating their own interests, ideas, and imaginations.

Beliefs about Learning

I believe that all students are basically good. The student is responsible for his or her own actions and choices. Students should be aware of environmental problems and able to develop solutions, whether in the classroom or in the real world. I agree with Dewey and feel that students should learn through inquiry and by stimulating their own interests and dreams. I do not believe that students are passive receptors of information, although passive learning occurs widely in schools today. With the teacher's guidance, students should take ownership of their learning experiences and actively become members of the learning community. I believe that if students are given the control to shape their own experiences, they will indeed

understand the broader scope of what education means to them and how they intend to use their experiences and knowledge later in life.

Beliefs about Teaching

I believe that teaching is a noble and important profession. The teacher can make an impact on a person's life in more ways than one can ever imagine. That one smile or kind word you offer as a teacher just might be the only positive interaction the student has all day. I believe that the teacher's role is to inspire others to believe in themselves and to reach out and help the struggling students by sparking their imaginations and lighting fires. My view of an ideal teacher is one who inspires learning, not just relays the required facts, and encourages both creative and analytic thinking. A certain amount of creativity, enthusiasm, and motivation is required of the teacher. A teacher is constantly searching for, developing, and implementing new ideas, continually generating ideas for future classroom implementation.

I believe the role of the teacher should be that of an inquiry leader, and the main purpose of education should be problem-solving through hands-on experience. The teacher's role is to facilitate learning by posing questions that exercise students' minds in practical ways. The teacher is responsible for preparing students for the real world, and it is within the classroom setting that teachers must recreate problems that exist in society and guide students toward solving them. I am in agreement with Progressivism that teachers are centered on an ever-changing society, and so today's problems are constantly becoming more intricate and complex, demanding that students use creativity and ingenuity to find the most viable solutions. Teachers act as liaisons between students and the real world, and it is their responsibility to introduce the reality of being a productive member of society to their students, as well as the expectations and obstacles that lie ahead on their path to success.

I am a teacher. It is important for me to have an impact on students. Student growth and development is a great source of personal satisfaction. When students feel success, I feel great! As a teacher, I have to be mindful that each student is different and that learning is, too. I have to be able to multitask, be consistent and firm, accept individual differences, and provide personal assistance to the students.

Beliefs about Curriculum and Teaching Methodologies

The curriculum belief places a strong emphasis on problem-solving, analysis, and rational thinking. These skills are important in today's society. I agree with a Progressivist curriculum centered on activities and instruction that challenge students' problem-solving and analytical abilities, thereby strengthening these skills.

I also believe that classroom support for problem-based learning plays an important role in students' learning. A student-centered curriculum is consistent with pragmatism, as it

addresses students' interests and needs as the starting point. The classroom environment would invite participation, involvement, and democratic learning. The lesson plans would be organized creatively and would involve lectures, discussions, research, experiments, and critical thinking. My lesson plans also have to be flexible to meet student needs. Not every student learns the same way, and lessons need to be engaging and tailored to all types of learners. Students will engage in hands-on activities to demonstrate their control over their learning. They are encouraged to learn by doing and to interact with one another. The teacher's role in my classroom is to encourage and facilitate the problem-solving process, rather than to provide prescribed solutions. Similarly, the learning environment is collaborative and democratic, giving opportunity for all to speak their minds and receive feedback from peers as well as the teacher. This continuous loop of feedback, potentially positive or negative, serves as the means of assessment for problem-solving-based instruction.

In retrospect, psychologically, I also integrate aspects of the humanistic approach into my curriculum. I have to be mindful of the basic rules for the classroom: respect for self, respect for others, respect for multiculturalism, and respect for physical, social, emotional, and intellectual needs. Problem-solving, discussion forums, and group projects will allow for a pragmatic approach to the curriculum.

Beliefs about Classroom Management

As important as the roles of the teacher and the curriculum, classroom management techniques are also very important. I believe the learning environment should be clean, safe, inviting, accepting, cooperative, and supportive of all of the students. My belief is that the role of the teacher is that of an administrator, facilitator, inquirer, and resource person; therefore, the relationship between the teacher and students is very important. I don't believe in a teacher as a boss. I want to be a likable person to my students and value a positive personal relationship. I want to be a teacher students respect, and as their teacher, I will respect them too. As a teacher, I need to set clear expectations, maintain flexibility, and foster mutual respect, all of which will contribute to classroom management. My belief is that when students feel comfortable in the classroom, a much greater degree of learning can take place. Both behaviorism and humanism are essential parts of my classroom management styles. My number one rule is to be respectful of each student's individual needs and interests.

Beliefs about Social Function of Educational Institutions

School is a social institution that underpins learning, and it must be built on a solid foundation of integrity, trust, and respect for mankind. My ideal school should be accessible to everyone, so that each person has the same opportunity to learn, regardless of their religion, ethnicity, socioeconomic background, or income. The school should accommodate every

student in the community, regardless of students' physical, social, emotional, and intellectual needs. The school should have a program to recruit and retain qualified teachers and, at the same time, a continuous training program for teachers. In addition, teachers should be given the necessary tools and equipment to facilitate learning activities. The learning environment should be clean, safe, and inviting. At the same time, the school should be operated on the basis of respect for the human spirit and for the promotion of cultural diversity. The school needs to establish an educational belief and mission. The school needs to establish an educational mission and goal. Educational belief is a principle that guides the practice. The mission is to set goals for practice. The belief and goal should be based on the students' and community's needs.

Conclusion

The question is "what is my personal philosophy of education?" I believe in Behaviorism, Essentialism, Perennialism, Progressivism, and Existentialism. I am closely aligned with the progressive approach. I am mindful of all educational theories and practices, and that each individual student learns differently, so I need to be flexible and adaptable to support students' success. If you are a teacher, a student, an administrator, a facilitator, an inquirer, or a resource person, then be a good one. For me, I want to be a good teacher, a "go-to" person for those who want to advance their lives. I was there and understood what it feels like to be alone and displaced. I want to give back all that I have learned and share these ideas so that disadvantaged students can find what they need to succeed. As a teacher, I want my students to be aware of the problems in our environment and to develop solutions, whether in the classroom or in the real world. As a teacher, my focus will be on the students, and they will be placed first in order of importance.

Reference Quotes

"In modern times there are opposing views about the practice of education. There is no general agreement about what the young should learn either in relation to virtue or in relation to the best life; nor is it clear whether their education ought to be directed more towards the intellect than towards the character of the soul.... And it is not certain whether training should be directed at things useful in life, or at those conducive to virtue, or at non-essentials.... And there is no agreement as to what, in fact, tends towards virtue. Men do not all prize most highly the same virtue, so naturally they differ also about the proper training for it." -Aristotle

"We move mountains by first moving ourselves, and the way we educate makes all the difference in the world. The choice is ours. We make the difference. It is we who decide to live, or not to live, our visions. We are the creators of the world and realities we live in. We are the ones who must choose the path of our learning." -Gregory Cajete.

“...You will need a vision that is truly your own—one that is deep and tenacious, and that lies close to the core of who you believe yourself to be, what you value in life, and where you see yourself going ...” -Jon Kabat-Zinn.

References

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